

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 2

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator recalls a Sunday afternoon spent learning to cook bak kut teh under the patient eye of her grandfather.

1

The first thing my grandfather taught me about bak kut teh was that the broth could tell when you were in a hurry. I had arrived at his flat at nine in the morning, already half-distracted by my phone, and he had looked at me for a long moment over the rim of his reading glasses. “Put that thing in the drawer,” he said, in the soft, mild voice he used only when he meant to be obeyed. I put it in the drawer. He nodded once, as though a small but important treaty had just been signed between us, and turned to the kitchen.

2

The ingredients were already laid out on the counter, each in its own little dish, the way a surgeon lays out his instruments. There were the pork ribs, pale and trimmed; the heads of garlic, still unpeeled and faintly purple; the dark, sticky bundle of his “spice packet”, which he had been making by hand since long before any supermarket sold one. He pointed at each in turn and said its name in Hokkien, then in English, and then waited for me to repeat them. My pronunciation was, by his expression, neither offensive nor encouraging. We moved on.

3

“The ribs go in cold water,” he said, “not boiling.” He filled a heavy clay pot from the tap, dropped the ribs in, and set it on a low flame. I asked, foolishly, why we did not just blanch them quickly to save time. He did not answer. He merely tilted his head, the way an old teacher tilts his head at a question that, in his opinion, the pupil already knows the answer to. Twenty minutes later, when a grey foam had risen slowly to the surface and he had skimmed it off with a slotted spoon, he glanced at me and said, “Hurried meat is bitter meat.” I have never forgotten it.

4

The kitchen, which had always been a small and slightly cluttered room, began to change. Steam rose in

shy ribbons from the pot. The smell — of pepper, of garlic gone gentle in heat, of the cassia bark he had broken into the spice packet — wrapped itself around the ceiling fan and slipped under the door. My grandfather sat down on a low wooden stool. He did not stir the pot. He did not lift the lid. He simply watched it, with the calm, absorbed attention of a man watching a slow river. After a while, without looking at me, he said, “You also sit. Sitting is part of the recipe.”

5

I sat. I had imagined, foolishly, that I would learn the dish in the way I learnt everything else — in a clean sequence of steps, perhaps written down. But there were no measurements on his counter, no timers on his stove, no recipe card pinned to the wall. He cooked by smell, by the colour of the broth, by the depth of a sound when a spoon tapped the side of the pot. When I asked him, half-laughing, how much white pepper he had used, he held up his thumb and forefinger and said, “This much. Sometimes a little more, if the weather is wet.” I wrote that down in my head, knowing already that it would be useless to anyone but me.

6

At noon he lifted the lid. The broth had darkened to the colour of strong tea. He ladled a little into a small bowl, blew on it, and passed it to me without ceremony. I tasted it. It was hot and clean and faintly sweet, with a peppery warmth that did not announce itself at first but lingered, like a thought one keeps returning to. I looked up at him. He was watching me, and for a single, embarrassing second I saw on his face the same anxious, hopeful expression my father wears when he has cooked something new for guests. Then it passed, and my grandfather only nodded and said, “Acceptable.”

7

We ate together at the small Formica table by the window. He told me, between mouthfuls, about his own grandfather, who had taught him this dish in a kitchen in Penang during the war, when pepper had been precious and pork had been scarce. He told me about cooking for my grandmother when she was newly married and frightened of the stove. He told me, finally and almost shyly, that he had been waiting “a long time” for somebody in the family to ask to learn. I did not know what to say to that. I picked up another rib instead, and he, perhaps relieved, did the same.

8

I cook bak kut teh now, in my own small kitchen, on Sunday mornings when I am not in a hurry. I still cannot quite match his broth — there is always something half a shade lighter, half a note shyer — and I suspect I never will. But I do not mind. The dish is no longer only a recipe. It is the low flame of an old stove, the smell of garlic going gentle, the steady patience of a man who once turned to me, in his quiet kitchen, and asked me, without asking, to slow down.

From Paragraph 1

1. The grandfather speaks “in the soft, mild voice he used only when he meant to be obeyed.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about the grandfather’s manner of giving instructions. [2]

2. The narrator says her grandfather nodded “as though a small but important treaty had just been signed between us.” What does this comparison suggest about the moment between them? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The ingredients are compared to the instruments of a surgeon. Explain what this comparison suggests about the grandfather’s approach to cooking. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The grandfather tilts his head “the way an old teacher tilts his head at a question that, in his opinion, the pupil already knows the answer to.” What does this tell us about how the grandfather wishes to teach the narrator? [2]

5. Explain, in your own words, what the grandfather means by “Hurried meat is bitter meat.” [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. Give **two** ways in which the writer makes the kitchen feel calm and unhurried in Paragraph 4. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. Explain how the language used in this paragraph emphasises the **difference** between the way the narrator usually learns and the way her grandfather cooks. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator describes the peppery warmth of the broth as “a thought one keeps returning to.”
(a) Identify the literary device used in this phrase. [1]
(b) Explain what the device suggests about the taste of the broth. [1]

9. What impression do you form of the grandfather from his single-word reply, “Acceptable”? [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. Why, in your opinion, does the narrator say she “did not know what to say” when her grandfather admits he had been waiting a long time for someone in the family to ask to learn? [1]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the science, ethics and current state of lab-grown (cultivated) meat.

1

Twelve years ago, a Dutch scientist stood in a small London television studio and watched two food critics chew, very slowly, on what he had spent more than a quarter of a million euros to grow. The patty in their mouths looked like a hamburger, smelt like a hamburger, and had, in fact, been made of beef — but no cow had been killed for it. Each strand of muscle had been coaxed, over several weeks, from a tiny sample of bovine cells in a steel tank. The verdict, after some hesitation, was polite: “close to meat”, said one critic. “Not quite juicy enough,” said the other. It was the dawn, the press declared, of a new agricultural age.

2

Today, the picture is more complicated. Several companies — in Singapore, in California, in the Netherlands, in Israel — have moved cultivated meat out of the laboratory and into regulated commercial sale. Singapore became, in 2020, the first country in the world to approve a cultivated chicken product for human consumption; the United States followed in 2023. The technology behind it has, in principle, changed rather little since that London demonstration. A small biopsy of cells, often taken painlessly from a living animal, is placed in a “bioreactor”: a steel vessel filled with a nutrient broth of sugars, amino acids and growth factors. There, under carefully controlled temperatures, the cells divide, mature, and form the protein fibres that we call meat.

3

The environmental case for cultivated meat is, on paper, striking. Livestock farming, according to the United Nations, accounts for roughly fourteen per cent of all human-caused greenhouse gas emissions; it uses nearly a third of the planet’s ice-free land; and it is one of the largest single drivers of deforestation in the tropics. A successful cultivated-meat industry, its supporters argue, could reduce the land used for meat production by more than ninety per cent, slash water use, and free vast tracts of farmland to be returned to forest. There is also a more immediate moral promise: a future in which the appetite for chicken nuggets does not require the slaughter, every year, of some seventy billion birds.

4

And yet — and here the picture grows ethically complicated — the technology is not as simple, or as clean, as its admirers sometimes suggest. The “nutrient broth” in which the cells grow has, until very recently, depended on a substance called foetal bovine serum, harvested from the blood of unborn calves; an animal-free meat that relies on an animal product is, plainly, no answer. Newer plant-based growth media are now in use, but they remain expensive. Critics also point out that the bioreactors themselves consume enormous quantities of electricity, and that, in countries where that electricity is generated by burning coal or gas, cultivated meat may end up no cleaner — and possibly dirtier — than the chicken it hopes to replace.

5

Consumers, meanwhile, are not yet convinced. A 2024 survey by the Food Standards Agency found that fewer than one in three British adults said they would willingly try cultivated meat, and only one in ten said they would eat it regularly. The objections were varied: some found the idea “unnatural”; some doubted, fairly enough, that anything grown in a steel tank could be properly described as food; some worried, quietly, about a future in which farmers were replaced by engineers. The industry’s preferred term — “cultivated meat” — has itself been the subject of fierce debate. Cattle ranchers in several American states have lobbied, with some success, to ban the word **meat** from any product not taken from a slaughtered animal.

6

The economics, too, remain stubborn. The original 2013 burger cost €250,000. By 2023 a cultivated chicken nugget could be sold, in Singapore, for roughly the price of a fine-dining starter. That is a remarkable fall — but it is still many times the price of an ordinary nugget at a fast-food counter. Several once-celebrated start-ups have closed; investment, which surged in 2021, has since cooled noticeably. Reaching what the industry calls “price parity” with conventional meat — the moment at which a shopper might choose cultivated chicken simply because it is cheaper — is, on the most optimistic forecasts, still a decade away.

7

None of this means the experiment has failed. It means, rather, that cultivated meat is, like all serious technologies, neither a miracle nor a fraud. It promises a kinder, leaner, less destructive way of eating; it carries real ethical costs of its own; and it must, in the end, prove itself in the unromantic arena of the supermarket shelf. Whether it succeeds depends on three things working together: cheaper inputs, cleaner energy, and a generation of eaters willing to consider that the future of food might come, quite literally, out of a tank.

From Paragraph 1

12. In Paragraph 1, the writer says the verdict on the first cultivated burger was “polite”. What does the use of inverted commas around this word suggest about the writer’s attitude towards that verdict? [2]

13. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 that shows the original cultivated burger was extremely expensive to produce. [1]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, explain in your own words how cultivated meat is made. You should not need more than three short sentences. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Give **two** ways in which, according to Paragraph 3, conventional livestock farming damages the environment. [2]

16. The writer says cultivated meat carries “a more immediate moral promise.” In your own words, what is this moral promise? [1]

From Paragraph 4

17. Explain how the writer uses **contrast** in Paragraph 4 to show that cultivated meat is not as ethically simple as its supporters claim. Support your answer with **two** details. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. Some consumers worry about “a future in which farmers were replaced by engineers.” Explain, in your own words, what this concern is really about. [2]

19. What does the writer’s use of the word “fiercely” (in the phrase “the subject of fierce debate”) suggest about the disagreement over the term **cultivated meat**? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says reaching “price parity” with conventional meat is “still a decade away”. What is the **tone** of this statement? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer concludes that cultivated meat is “neither a miracle nor a fraud.” Explain what is **effective** about this way of summing up the technology. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the benefits that supporters claim for cultivated meat**, and **the concerns that people still have about it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Supporters argue that cultivated meat could ...

— END OF PAPER —